woes, the India–Pakistan match started at 6 p.m. and finished close to midnight. I had driven from Yorkshire to London for the early-evening start and by the time the match was over I was exhausted.

Afterwards the other players were heading back to the hotel in London to relax and they asked me to join them. When I said I had to leave for Newcastle because I was playing there the next day I could see the shock and bewilderment on their faces. I had wrongly believed that it was easy to get from any part of England to another in two or three hours. It was only when they told me that it would take a minimum of six or seven hours to drive there that I realized the seriousness of the situation. I was advised to leave for Newcastle straight away. I was stumped. I had left Yorkshire at one o'clock that afternoon to get down to London, and here I was at midnight getting ready to drive all the way to Newcastle.

Jatin Paranjpe was with me at the time and we set off on the long drive together. Unfortunately, we had little knowledge of the roads and were completely dependent on the signs. To add to our misery, we missed a turn and ended up going south for close to thirty-five minutes when we should have been driving north. It was just one of those nights.

After driving for a couple of hours, my eyes started to give way. I asked Jatin to drive while I napped to regain a bit of energy. Jatin did so and after a few minutes I took my turn in the driver's seat again. A coffee break helped and eventually we reached the hotel at 8.15 a.m., only to see the team bus about to leave for the ground. We were both pretty much out of it by then and desperately needed to close our eyes. I walked up to the team manager and explained to him my plight and asked if he could possibly let me have twenty-five minutes of sleep. I promised to join the team at the ground in an hour. He was most kind and I set the alarm at exactly twenty-five minutes.

When I woke up I didn't know where I was and felt like a complete zombie. I stumbled out of the hotel and made my way to the ground. I was sleepy and tired and was in no physical state to play a day's cricket. I still find it hard to believe, but somehow I managed to go out and make a hundred. After lunch, however, I could hardly stay awake and for the first time in my life I was taking ten-second naps between overs. I was actually sleeping while fielding and don't really know how I managed to get through the rest of the game.

As soon as the match was over Jatin and I rushed to the hotel. Our plan was to sleep for a couple of hours before joining the rest of the team